gelling. How is that Paki post firing on this post of ours when it is at a lower height? Or how is this post of ours firing an MMG when it doesn't have one? All these queries would have to be followed-up during the day and would normally have a logical explanation—the MMG had been temporarily re-sited for instance. This attention to detail would keep us, the Staff, on our toes. I would, of course, in turn, haul up the Adjutants for not keeping me updated.

Although a field area, families were allowed to come for up to three months at a time. During the summer or winter breaks Veena, Isha and Amala would join me at Sunderbani. Coming from Pune to Jammu in the Jhelum Express with two kids in tow was no mean task. But Veena would manage this on her own, keeping the girls fed and entertained. Isha and Amala have always been good travellers, always enjoying the adventure without any fuss or tantrums. I would go down from Sunderbani to Jammu to pick them up, and Brig Sandhu would often ask me to take his staff car for this purpose. I had a two-room set as my house, each with an attached bath. The second bath was converted into a makeshift kitchen, where Veena would make wholesome khichdi (a dish made of rice and lentils) for the girls, before sending them out to play. They would wander about the HQ, Isha holding on tightly to Amala's hand. They would go to the Officers' Mess and have their fill of saunf (fennel seeds) and shakkar (sugar) and were nicknamed thus. Perhaps their father raiding the Officers' Mess at Devlali had rubbed off on them. Evenings we would go for long walks, enjoying the fresh air and beauty of the Sunderbani Valley, or for a picnic on the banks of the Munawar Tawi (river). It was quite idyllic and gave Veena a chance to relax and de-stress after being on her own at Pune, looking single-handedly after home and hearth. At the end of their stay, I would accompany them back to Pune as I would be

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